Travis McKenna

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AOS Philosophy of Science, Philosophy of Physics, Metaphysics
AOC Philosophy of Mathematics, Philosophy of Language

Employment

Assistant Professor 2025 – Present
North Carolina State University
Department of Philosophy and Religious Studies

Ahmanson Postdoctoral Instructor in Philosophy of Science 2024 – 2025
California Institute of Technology
Division of Humanities and Social Sciences

Education

University of Pittsburgh 2018 – 2024
PhD in Philosophy
Dissertation: Laws of Nature and their Supporting Casts
Committee: Bob Batterman (co-chair), Mark Wilson (co-chair), David Wallace, Erica Shumener, Gordon Belot.

University of Sydney 2014 – 2017
BSci (Honours) in Mathematics and Philosophy

University of Sydney 2008 – 2011
BA (Honours) in Ancient History and Modern Languages

Publications

Laws of Nature and their Supporting Casts
The British Journal for the Philosophy of Science, forthcoming.

Structure and Applied Mathematics
Synthese, 200(5):1–31, 2022.

Lange on Minimal Model Explanations: A Defense of Batterman and Rice
Philosophy of Science, 88(4):731–741, 2021.

Talks

* = invited

What is an Instance of a Law of Nature?
– *May 2025, Workshop on Method, Theory, and Reality, UMass, Amherst.
– September 2022, Conceptual Innovation in Classical Mechanics, University of Seville.

The Coordinating Role of Laws in Empirical Science
– *April 2024, Workshop on Method, Theory, and Reality, UMass, Amherst.

Fundamental Laws and the Methodology of Science (with Gabrielle Kerbel)
– February 2024, American Philosophical Association, Central Division Meeting.
– August 2023, Society for the Metaphysics of Science Conference

Laws of Nature and their Supporting Casts
– July 2022, Summer School on Laws and Chances, Central European University.

Contextualism and Kripke's Puzzle About Belief
– July 2019, Australasian Association of Philosophy Conference, University of Adelaide.

Comments

Ulrich Meyer, "Best Systems in Lawless Worlds" — August 2023
Society for the Metaphysics of Science Conference, Dalhousie University

Teaching

Primary Instructor

North Carolina State University

Philosophy of Science	Spring 2026
Metaphysics	Spring 2026
Philosophy of Science	Fall 2025

California Institute of Technology

Knowledge and Reality	Spring 2025
Introduction to Philosophy of Science	Fall 2024

University of Pittsburgh

Introduction to Bioethics	Fall 2023
Introduction to Ethics	Summer 2022

Teaching Assistant

University of Pittsburgh

Introduction to Logic (Thomas Berry)	Spring 2024
Philosophy of Mind (Rachael Driver)	Spring 2021
Concepts of Human Nature (Greg Strom)	Fall 2020
Introduction to Ethics (Nandi Theunissen)	Spring 2020
Introduction to Logic (Dmitri Gallow)	Fall 2019

University of Sydney

Philosophy of Law (Lukas Opacic)	Fall 2017

Service

Reviewer for *Philosophical Studies*, *British Journal for the Philosophy of Science*, *Synthese*, *Philosophy of Science*, *Studies in the History and Philosophy of Science*, *European Journal for the Philosophy of Science*, *Theoria*, and *Topoi*.

University of Pittsburgh

Undergraduate Philosophy Mentor	2019 – 2022
Graduate Student Representative to the Faculty	2020 – 2022
Member of the Climate and Liaison Committee	2020 – 2022
Member of the Student-Faculty Colloquium Organising Committee	2020 – 2024
Member of Metaphysics and Epistemology Search Committee	2022 – 2023
Chair of the Pitt-CMU Graduate Conference Committee	2022 – 2024

References

Robert Batterman
Distinguished Professor of Philosophy
University of Pittsburgh
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Mark Wilson
Distinguished Professor of Philosophy
University of Pittsburgh
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David Wallace
W.A. Mellon Professor of Philosophy of Science
University of Pittsburgh
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Gordon Belot
Lawrence Sklar Collegiate Professor of Philosophy
University of Michigan
belot@umich.edu

Erica Shumener
Assistant Professor of Philosophy
Syracuse University
eshumene@syr.edu

Porter Williams (Teaching)
Assistant Professor of Philosophy
University of Pittsburgh
pdw27@pitt.edu

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